

RKC1430

Roman Keycard Blackwood (RKC 1430)

Used to count key cards (the four aces plus the king of trumps) before bidding slam.

The Ask

4NT = asking for key cards (must have a clearly established trump suit)

The “1430” naming refers to the responses:

Response	Key cards held
5♣	1 or 4 key cards
5♦	0 or 3 key cards
5♥	2 key cards, no trump queen
5♠	2 key cards, with trump queen
5NT	2 key cards and a void

The Queen Ask

After a 5♣ or 5♦ response: - **5 of trumps** = sign off (not interested in the queen) -
Cheapest bid that is not trumps = queen ask

Response to queen ask	Meaning
5 of trumps (or 6 if forced)	No trump queen
6 of trumps	Has trump queen

Examples: - Trumps are **spades**, response 5♣: 5♦ (queen ask) - 5♠ (no) / 6♠ (yes). Sign off = 5♠ directly. - Trumps are **spades**, response 5♦: 5♥ (queen ask) - 5♠ (no) / 6♠ (yes). Sign off = 5♠ directly. - Trumps are **hearts**, response 5♣: 5♦ (queen ask) - 5♥ (no) / 6♥ (yes). Sign off = 5♥ directly. - Trumps are **hearts**, response 5♦: 5♠ (queen ask) - but now “no” = 6♥, so you’re already at slam.

The queen ask can force you to the 6-level — this happens with hearts (after a 5♦ response) and always with minors. Only ask for the queen when you can afford to be at

6 if the answer is no, or when trumps are spades (always safe). This is part of why the guidelines below warn against using RKC when you could be forced past 5 of trumps.

When to Use / When NOT to Use RKC

Use 4NT when: - Trump suit is clearly agreed or unambiguously implied - You have no two fast losers in any side suit - You're in slam-investigation range and need keycard information

Don't use 4NT when: - **You have a void** — partner's key card in your void suit is worthless, and you can't evaluate accurately. Use cue bids instead, or Exclusion Blackwood if you play it. - **No trump suit is agreed** — 4NT is ambiguous and might be natural/quantitative after a NT opening or when no suit has been bid and supported. - **You're not in slam range** — don't fish for information you won't act on. - **You'd be forced past 5 of trumps** — if the response could land you at the 6-level with two keycards missing, don't ask. - **After 1NT or 2NT** without an agreed fit — 4NT is quantitative, not Blackwood. - **Partner has shown a very weak hand** — Blackwood can't fix a bad trump suit or missing controls in side suits.